GG EZ Game Design Document

GG EZ is a short fighting-game prototype about the impulse to insult a stranger after losing. The current build contains a repeatable match, reply and room-visit loop. The thirteen-scene story is a production plan, not a playable campaign.

Carl Kho and Dain Kim · 31 October 2026 · Checkpoint Game Jam, theme: Play to Prevent.

Implementation baseline: `main.gd` at commit `96537b5`. Story sources: `docs/storyboards/ACT3-TABLES.md`, `docs/storyboards/ACT45-TABLES.md` and their linked boards. Repository: https://github.com/CarlKho-Minerva/gg-ez.

1. The player loses, then gets three seconds to reply

You lose an online fighting match. The opponent types “ez”. Two replies appear beside a three-second clock. Letting it expire is a third choice: silence.

The intended checkpoint is the return of that same choice after seeing the other person’s room. We use “checkpoint” here as our working design term for a pause in an automatic hostile response. The story asks whether knowing something about a stranger changes what the player presses. It does not claim that a game about trash talk prevents radicalisation.

The planned opening and final chat have the same framing, wording and reply window. The approved storyboard pair is “okay that was clean” and “fuck off”. The runtime still uses “wow, you’re good” and “fuck you” (`OPT_NICE`, `OPT_MEAN`). Those quoted insults are game content, not the document’s voice.

The build records choices and elapsed reply times. No player study or evidence of lasting behaviour change is presented here. A different reply within one run would be a description of that run, not proof of prevention.

2. The current build repeats a rigged match

The runtime is a rage loop, not the story’s three-match arc. Its thresholds come from `main.gd`; its overall play length is unmeasured.

1. **Fight.** Move, jump and attack in a side-view arena. The move table assigns damage ranges from 2 to 7 percentage points (`MOVES`). At 90 percent opponent damage, an attack input is delayed by 0.45 seconds and an in-range attack misses once. Lia starts firing a decisive attack at that threshold or after the 30-second match timer. She keeps firing until it lands (`_update_you`, `_attack`, `_update_her`), so 30 seconds is not a measured hard limit on the round.
2. **Reply.** After the knockout, Lia taunts the player. The reply window is 3 seconds (`REPLY_WINDOW`). Silence is recorded when the next update notices expiry; the stored time is actual elapsed time, not fixed at exactly 3000 milliseconds (`_on_choice`).
3. **Rematch or leave.** RAGE QUIT appears after 3 losses since the last room visit. The controller is thrown automatically after 5 (`RAGE_AFTER`, `FORCED_AFTER`). Its impact cracks the screen and reveals her room.
4. **Look around.** Click room objects to read a line about them. Later visits expose more objects. The phone opens a conversation. Her portrait and screen then show the other side of the exchange before another queue.

5. **End.** Two consecutive kind replies after at least one room visit, 8 losses, or “log off” lead to an end card and feedback form (`nice_streak`, `visits`, `MAX_LOSSES`). The first kind reply is deliberately shown as unsent and does not count toward the streak.

The last rule matters: the runtime rewards a kind-reply streak by ending the loop. The proposed ending instead avoids an empathy score or a labelled correct answer. They are different designs.

`HANDOFF.md` records an earlier end-to-end self-playing test at commit `d2b3970`. That historical test does not certify the current build or the planned scenes.

What the build records

All events pass through `_track`. With the current empty `POSTHOG_KEY`, that function does not send analytics to PostHog. This statement concerns the game’s analytics code, not unrelated hosting requests.

Record	Contents	Destination in the current configuration
Choice	Reply or silence, elapsed milliseconds, loss number	Console; included in the loop summary
Play events	Start, queue, knockout, rematch, rage quit, object look, log off	Console
Result	Picks, visits, end reason, loop entries	Console and attempted local append to `user://feedback.jsonl`
Feedback	Form answers and run summary	Console and attempted local append to the same file

Local saving depends on the file opening successfully; the runtime does not report a failed open. Manual rage quit records loss counts, while forced rage quit also adds `forced: true`. The game does not send a player’s chosen reply to another player. Enabling analytics would require a separate privacy and reliability review.

3. The story has thirteen scenes; only parts have runtime counterparts

The full plan uses an arena and Lia’s bedroom across five acts. The table below separates the intended action from the existing implementation. A room reveal or end card is not completion of the corresponding story scene.



Figure 1. Planned scene order and current production evidence. Filled squares mark scenes with a partial runtime counterpart, outlined circles mark graybox-only scenes, and triangles mark table-only scenes. These are production states, not completion percentages. The order is not a measured play clock; the only timing shown is the planned three-second reply window in storyboard cards M2.6 and E.1.

Scene 8, the customer call, is the main next story task. Figure 1 makes the gap visible: the prototype has repeated matches and a room, but not the work sequence or fair final fight. Storyboard timings are draft holds, often player-paced; no total campaign duration is asserted.

Scene	Intended action	Current evidence and gap
1. Title	Start and find lia_ph	Title, username and queue exist; planned menu details remain a graybox
2. First loss	Lose and answer “ez”	Rigged match and timed reply exist; not the exact staged storyboard exchange
3. Broken screen	Throw controller and cross through the crack	Throw, crack and reveal exist; crossing choreography remains partial
4. Wrong room	Float and watch Lia replay her win	Room reveal exists; no ghost movement or replay beat
5. Exploration	Read badge, phone or food	Progressive hotspots exist; not the planned first-visit scene
6. Second match	Lose with one inner line tied to an observed object	Rematch exists; no object-dependent inner line
7. Return	See the same room in work mode	Graybox only; no runtime work-mode arrival

Scene	Intended action	Current evidence and gap
8. Call	Watch a refund call and a quality review	Graybox only; no runtime call
9. Message home	See her message her mother and photograph dinner	Proposal tables only
10. One more game	Read the exchange with her friend Mika	Proposal tables only
11. Longest night	Observe the shift pass, then approach the monitor	Proposal tables only
12. Fair fight	Play a stable match that can be won or lost	Proposal tables only; current matches remain rigged
13. Last reply	Answer the same chat, then see “Good morning”	Runtime end card only; planned final chat and epilogue absent

The repository tables document grayboxes for scenes 6–8 in `ACT3-TABLES.md` and proposals for scenes 9–13 in `ACT45-TABLES.md`. Earlier scene boards are linked in the team’s existing design record; the local tables, rather than current remote board contents, are the status source here. Editable board: https://www.figma.com/design/9n83sdzD1t2Fm3asaMi1Hs/GG-EZ.

Three rules for the proposed story

- **The ghost observes, never intervenes.** It cannot touch anything, speak to Lia or fix her circumstances. She never knows it is there. The current runtime has `GHOST = false`; it shows the other side without implementing this character.
- **One faulty connection links both rooms.** The broken screen sends the player into her room; another queue brings them back. There is no separate afterlife explanation.
- **Winning is independent of empathy.** The planned final match allows either outcome. Understanding Lia is not a combat upgrade. This is not true of the current rigged-match loop.

4. Lia is competitive before she is sympathetic

In the proposed story, Lia (lia_ph) lives in Lapu-Lapu City and takes customer calls remotely during a night shift. She games during a scheduled break. She is skilled, funny, competitive and sometimes inconsiderate. Her working conditions explain the evening without excusing every action.

Her voice depends on who she is addressing: gamer slang to strangers, Cebuano to family, scripted English to customers. The runtime still says Quezon City and uses the older phone copy. The draft Cebuano and customer-call dialogue need independent language and workplace review before they are treated as finished.

The player is a username whose character comes from their choices. Dain’s proposed fighters are a wolf for the player and a wizard for Lia. The ghost retains the wolf’s ears and muzzle but replaces its legs with a floating tail. Those drawn designs and the ghost are intended replacements, not a claim about the generated runtime art.

5. Repeat the frame so the person changes its meaning

The staging uses SANABI as a composition reference, credited to WONDER POTION and NEOWIZ. These are our design choices, not verified quotations from its director. The local storyboard tables describe how to apply them.

1. Establish the arena wide. Move closer when frustration becomes the subject.
2. Give the chat the same crop and scale at the opening and ending. Do not announce a correct answer with a new colour or celebratory effect.
3. Match the monitor's position across the crossing. Let the fan be heard before the room is revealed.
4. Show Lia's humour before work pressure. The first visit is not a tour of hardship.
5. Repeat the wide room on the second visit. Changed posture and voice should explain the change before the camera moves (`ACT3-TABLES.md`, V2.2).
6. Hold after the call; avoid a dramatic camera move on every line. Return wide when the work resumes (C1.8, C1.13).
7. End with her life continuing. A polite reply does not fix her shift (`ACT45-TABLES.md`, E.3–E.7).

The proposed palette separates the vivid arena from the warm bedroom and cooler work-screen light. The room should not become colourless when the subject turns serious. Sound follows the same distinction: arcade noise gives way to fan and room tone, then to the work call. These are staging targets, not claims that every cue is implemented.

6. Reuse the room, then add the missing performance

The current `assets/` directory contains an arena background, bedroom reveal, fighters, controller, screen crack and two Lia portraits. `assets/sfx/` contains effects and room, screen and street ambience. Their presence does not establish a finished cinematic sequence.

Reuse from the prototype	Add for the story
Arena, match/reply interface, queue	A fair final match and outcome branches
Room background and hotspots	Work-mode room, call interface and staged phone scenes
Two portraits and generated fighter assets	Dain's portraits, fighters and Lia's seated performance
Crack and controller transition	Ghost form, movement and return transition
Effects and ambient clips	Call audio and scene-specific sound timing

After the jam, the proposed order is:

1. Reconcile reply wording and locale, review the language, then implement the ghost rather than merely changing its framing flag.
2. Build scenes 7 and 8 from the grayboxes. Protect the call scene if scope must shrink.
3. Replace generated art and develop scenes 9–13, including the fair final match and shared epilogue.

This PDF describes design and implementation status. It does not verify an uploaded package, a live submission page or the current export archive.

7. Test whether the pause reads as a choice, not a lesson

The design has moved from a short story proposal to a repeatable prototype and editable scene boards. That is evidence of iteration, not evidence that the intended audience finds it effective. No new participant feedback was collected for this document.

The next human playtest should ask whether the loss feels unfair but understandable, whether the reply window allows a deliberate choice, and whether the room reveals a person rather than a moral lesson. Observe where players hesitate or become confused, then revise the relevant beat. Review the dialogue with a Cebuano speaker and someone familiar with Philippine customer-support work. Those are planned checks, not completed reviews.

Choice logs can describe a before-and-after within one session. They cannot establish lasting change, distinguish empathy from learning how to end the loop, or remove the bias introduced by the first unsent kind reply. The feedback form is self-report. Claims about prevention require evidence beyond this prototype.

AI use and credits

The repository records AI-assisted code and storyboard drafting, generated runtime art, Meshy fighter models, ElevenLabs sound and Pexels intro footage. Dain’s drawn art is the planned replacement direction. SANABI is a composition reference only, not GG EZ art or training material. This document was revised and source-checked with AI assistance.